

Front Desk Patient Intake & Privacy Protocol

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Purpose & scope

Guides reception and intake coordinators at Northgate Medical Group clinics for new and returning patient check-in while protecting PHI under HIPAA-aligned office policy. Covers verification, forms, copay collection, and waiting-room privacy.

Key terms

PHI: Protected health information — name, DOB, diagnosis, insurance ID, appointment reason spoken aloud.

Minimum necessary: Share only information required to complete the task.

Verification triad: Full legal name, date of birth, last four of SSN or photo ID.

Standard procedure

1. Greet patient at desk; do not ask for appointment reason in open waiting room — use check-in kiosk or lowered voice.
2. Verify identity with verification triad; match to appointment in EHR (MedFlow).
3. Confirm insurance card is current; scan front and back; note copay amount in system.
4. Hand patient HIPAA notice if first visit in calendar year; obtain signature on tablet.
5. Provide clipboard or tablet for demographic updates; offer private alcove if patient needs assistance.
6. Inform patient of estimated wait; call by first name only unless duplicate first names in queue.

Approved phrases

"Welcome to Northgate. I'll verify a few details to pull up your chart — may I see your photo ID?"

"Your copay today is forty dollars — we accept card or HSA. Would you like a receipt by email?"

"For privacy, I'll ask about your visit reason when we step to the side of the desk."

"The physician is running about fifteen minutes behind. You're checked in — we'll call you shortly."

Scenarios

Scenario A — New patient, incomplete forms: Patient arrives 10 minutes early without online forms. Coordinator verifies ID, offers tablet in alcove, flags incomplete allergy list for nurse pre-visit.

Scenario B — Wrong DOB in system: Names match but DOB off by one day. Coordinator does not read chart aloud; asks patient to confirm DOB quietly; updates with supervisor badge if correction needed.

Scenario C — Family member asking for status: Visitor asks if "Mom is still in with Dr. Patel." Coordinator confirms visitor policy; does not confirm patient presence; offers to relay message through clinical staff.

Escalation matrix

Situation	Action
Patient refuses ID	Supervisor; no service without verification except emergency
Suspected identity theft	Supervisor + compliance officer
Aggressive behavior in lobby	Security protocol LOB-003; other patients relocated
Medical emergency in waiting room	Call code team; do not move patient unless trained

Do / Don't

Do: Position monitor away from public view; shred misprints immediately; use encrypted fax for records requests.

Don't: Discuss diagnoses at front desk; leave sign-in sheets visible; confirm another patient's appointment to a third party without written authorization.